

Decacorn 2040 Challenge

Build a \$10B Company by 2040

Context

In an era defined by rapid technological advancement, geopolitical shifts, and pressing global challenges, the most successful companies are those that not only solve immediate problems but also anticipate future needs and scale exponentially. This competition invites aspiring entrepreneurs and innovators to conceptualise and plan a startup that could achieve a \$10 billion valuation by 2040. Drawing inspiration from real-world unicorns and decacorns, your task is to demonstrate visionary thinking, rigorous analysis, and practical execution strategies.

This exercise goes beyond ideation; it's a holistic simulation of entrepreneurship. Participants must integrate market insights, technological innovation, organisational design, financial modelling, and cultural leadership into a cohesive blueprint. By focusing on sectors with high growth potential and relevance to emerging economies like India, the competition emphasises solutions that can drive both economic impact and societal benefit. Success in this challenge requires striking a balance between ambition and realism, creativity and data-driven decisions, and short-term tactics and long-term vision.

The Challenge

Design a startup that tackles a significant global issue, with particular emphasis on its implications and opportunities in India. Your company should operate in one of the following high-impact sectors, chosen based on their potential for disruption, scalability, and alignment with global trends:

- **Climate-Tech:** Innovations in carbon capture and sequestration, renewable energy sources (e.g., solar, wind, or advanced biofuels), sustainable materials (e.g., biodegradable plastics or eco-friendly construction), or climate resilience technologies like water management systems.
- **Healthcare:** Solutions for affordable medical devices (e.g., portable diagnostics), AI-powered diagnostics and predictive health analytics, telemedicine platforms for remote access, or biotech advancements in personalised medicine and disease prevention.
- **AI & Automation:** Applications in industry optimization (e.g., supply chain automation), predictive analytics for business intelligence, robotics for manufacturing or service sectors, or AI-driven tools for education, agriculture, or urban planning.
- **Defence & Security:** Developments in cybersecurity (e.g., AI-based threat detection), surveillance systems (e.g., drone technology or satellite monitoring), autonomous systems for defence operations, or secure communication networks resilient to cyber threats.

Your comprehensive plan must address the following key components in detail, ensuring that every element supports the overarching goal of reaching a \$10 billion valuation by 2040.

The Idea & Sector

- **Problem Identification:** Clearly articulate the global problem your startup addresses, including its scale, urgency, and specific relevance to India (e.g., urban pollution in climate-tech or rural healthcare access gaps). Use data or examples to quantify the issue, such as affected populations, economic costs, or environmental impacts.
- **Solution Description:** Detail your product, service, or technology, explaining its core features, how it works, and why it's innovative. Highlight unique differentiators, such as proprietary technology, cost advantages, or novel business models (e.g., subscription-based AI tools or pay-per-use medical devices).
- **Market Analysis:** Provide a thorough overview of the target market, including its current size (e.g., global and Indian Total Addressable Market, or TAM/, or SAM/, or SOM), projected growth rates (citing trends such as Compound Annual Growth Rate, or CAGR, from reliable sources), key competitors (with their strengths/weaknesses), and barriers to entry. Discuss regulatory environments, customer segments, and potential risks, including market saturation and technological obsolescence.

Initial Team & Structure

- **Founding Team:** Outline the core founders (3–5 individuals) with fictional or hypothetical profiles, including their expertise, backgrounds, and roles (e.g., CEO for vision and strategy, CTO for tech development, CMO for marketing). Emphasise complementary skills and why this team is uniquely positioned to succeed.
- **Initial Team Size:** Estimate the total headcount needed for launch (e.g., 10–20 people), broken down by functions like engineering, sales, operations, and support. Justify the size based on minimum viable product (MVP) requirements and early-stage efficiency.
- **Leadership Roles for Scaling:** Describe evolving organisational structure, including key hires at growth stages (e.g., VP of Finance for Series A, C-suite expansions for international growth). Include responsibilities such as talent acquisition, performance management, and decision-making frameworks to ensure agility and accountability.

Funding & Investment Plan

- **Capital Requirements:** Calculate the initial capital needs for phases such as R&D, prototyping, marketing, and operations (e.g., \$500K–\$2M for the seed stage). Break down costs into categories like personnel, technology, legal, and overhead, with assumptions for burn rate and runway.
- **Fundraising Roadmap:** Map out funding stages from Seed (e.g., \$1–5M for MVP and early traction) to Series A (e.g., \$10–20M for product-market fit), B (e.g., \$30–50M for scaling), C (e.g., \$100M+ for expansion), and beyond to growth equity or IPO/PE exit. Specify milestones for each round, such as user acquisition targets, revenue thresholds, or geographic expansions.
- **Investor Strategy:** Discuss target investors (e.g., angel networks, VCs focused on impact investing, or government grants in India), valuation projections at each stage, and equity dilution considerations. Include contingency plans for economic downturns or funding delays.

Revenue Model & Growth Strategy

- **Early Revenue Generation:** Explain monetisation in the first 3–5 years, such as B2B SaaS subscriptions, freemium models, hardware sales with recurring services, or partnerships (e.g., licensing tech to enterprises). Provide high-level projections, such as Year 1: \$100K (pilot revenues), and Year 3: \$5M (break-even).
- **Long-Term Forecasts:** Project revenue growth to 2040, using assumptions like customer acquisition cost (CAC), lifetime value (LTV), and churn rates. Aim for exponential scaling (e.g., 100% YoY growth initially, tapering to 30–50%), culminating in \$10B+ annual revenue to support the valuation (assuming 10–20x multiples).
- **Scaling Tactics:** Develop detailed strategies for growth, including market expansion (e.g., from India to the APAC region, then globally), strategic partnerships (e.g., with conglomerates or governments), mergers & acquisitions (e.g., acquiring complementary startups), and diversification (e.g., entering adjacent sectors). Address operational scaling, like supply chain optimisation or tech infrastructure upgrades.

Leadership & Culture

- **Core Values and Principles:** Define 4–6 guiding principles (e.g., innovation, integrity, sustainability, inclusivity) that shape decision-making and behaviour. Explain how these align with the company's mission and sector focus.
- **Team Alignment and Motivation:** Describe mechanisms for maintaining cohesion, such as regular all-hands meetings, equity incentives, professional development programs, and feedback loops. Discuss diversity and inclusion initiatives to foster creativity and resilience.
- **Navigating Challenges:** Outline approaches to common scaling hurdles, like cultural shifts during rapid growth, ethical dilemmas in high-stakes sectors, or global crises. Emphasise adaptive leadership styles, crisis management protocols, and a focus on long-term employee well-being to build an enduring organisation.

Deliverables

To submit your entry, prepare the following materials, ensuring they are professional, data-backed, and visually engaging:

- **Business Plan Deck (20 Slides at max):** A slide presentation covering all challenge sections, with clear visuals, charts, and minimal text per slide.
- **Financial & Investment Forecasts:** A spreadsheet or appended document with detailed projections, including income statements, cash flow models, balance sheets, and sensitivity analyses. Include key assumptions (e.g., growth rates, margins) and scenarios (optimistic, base, pessimistic).
- **Strategic Scaling Roadmap:** A visual timeline or Gantt chart illustrating milestones from inception (e.g., MVP launch in Year 1) to \$10B valuation (e.g., IPO in 2035–2040), with dependencies, risks, and metrics for success (Include in PPT)

Judging Criteria

Entries will be evaluated by Team ShareIITK

- **Innovation & Disruption (25%):** Assesses the originality, boldness, and transformative potential of the idea. High scores for solutions that redefine industries or create new markets, with strong IP or tech edge.
- **Strategic Planning (25%):** Evaluates the depth, feasibility, and logic of the growth, scaling, and funding strategies. Look for realistic milestones, risk mitigation, and alignment between plans.
- **Market Understanding & Financial Insight (20%):** Reviews the accuracy of market analysis, revenue models, and projections. Rewards data-driven insights, sound assumptions, and robust financial modelling.
- **Leadership & Organisational Culture (15%):** Judges the strength and authenticity of the leadership manifesto, team structure, and cultural elements. Prioritises plans that promote sustainable, ethical growth.
- **Clarity & Presentation (15%):** Scores the overall coherence, storytelling flow, and visual quality of the deliverables. Effective communication, logical structure, and error-free materials are key.

This competition is an opportunity to showcase your ability to think like a founder-CEO. Submissions should be original, self-contained, and demonstrate a passion for building world-changing companies. Good luck!

Team Size

Total of 8, comprising a minimum of 4 Y25S and a minimum of 3 Y24S.